

Chapter

Antakāle Ca — The Om of the Final Breath



Introduction: What Should We Do at the Time of Death?

Many people believe that if they utter God's name, or "Om", at the moment of death, liberation is assured. In the eighth chapter of the Shrimad Bhagavad Gita, Lord Shri Krishna himself explains what is to be done at the final hour. But Acharya Upendra Ji opens up these verses word by word to show that this method is not a practice for the last moment. It is the practice of an entire lifetime.

Acharya Ji begins with a question:

"What has been said that we should do at the time of death?"

The Lord first introduces the supreme state that is to be reached:

**yad akṣaram veda-vido vadanti viśanti yad yatayo
vīta-rāgāḥ**

**yad icchanto brahmacaryaṁ caranti tat te padaṁ
saṅgrahena pravakṣye**

"That which the knowers of the Veda call
imperishable, which ascetics free from attachment
enter, and desiring which seekers practise
brahmacharya, that state I shall describe to you in
brief."

— Bhagavad Gita 8.11

The supreme state of **Sachchidananda** (existence-consciousness-bliss) that the learned call imperishable, which detached renunciates enter, and for which seekers

practise celibacy: the Lord describes it in brief. Acharya Ji calls it **the state of Omkara**, and adds:

"There it has only been told in brief; I am teaching it to you in detail."

1. Closing the Doors of the Senses

The next two verses describe the method for the final hour:

**sarva-dvārāṇi saṁyamya mano hṛdi nirudhya ca
mūrdhny ādhāyātmanaḥ prāṇam āsthito yoga-
dhāraṇām**

"Restraining all the doors of the senses, confining
the mind in the heart, placing the life-breath in the
head, established in yogic concentration..."

— Bhagavad Gita 8.12

The first step is to **close all the doors of the senses**. Acharya Ji explains it in simple words:

"It means stopping the work of all your sense organs. If there is eating and drinking, then no eating now; let go of all that desire. Nothing to smell with the nose now, nothing to hear with the ears, nothing to see."

2. The Mind in the Heart, with Selfless Love

The second step is **to steady the mind in the region of the heart**. According to Acharya Ji, this is not only a place to meditate on. It is the attitude of the practice:

"It means in the heart, meaning doing it selflessly. Sadhana is not to be done for some reason, because 'I want some benefit'."

"Steadying the mind in the heart means with **unconditional love for the Lord**."

Settling the mind in the heart means loving God without conditions and without hoping for any gain.

3. The Life-Force at the Third Eye: Union with the Guru Principle

The third step is to use that conquered mind to place the prana in the head. Acharya Ji explains what "the head" means:

"In the head means taking it to the third eye, the union with the Guru principle. It means, while remembering the Guru, gathering the prana, the whole life force energy, there at the third eye..."

In this way the seeker becomes established in yoga-dharana, yogic concentration on the Supreme.

4. Om: Brahman as a Single Syllable

Now comes the verse that names the Omkara:

om ity ekākṣaram brahma vyāharan mām
anusmaran
yaḥ prayāti tyajan dehaṁ sa yāti paramām gatim
"Uttering Om, the single-syllable Brahman, and
remembering Me, he who departs leaving the body
attains the supreme goal."
— Bhagavad Gita 8.13

"The person who, uttering Om, this single-syllable Brahman..." Here Acharya Ji stops at the word "person" (**purusha**):

"The one who does it has been called 'purusha'.
Purusha means you yourself are the Supreme Lord."

He then names three forms of Brahman:

- **Akshara Brahman**: "Om", Brahman in the form of a single syllable
- **Shabda Brahman**: "the Shabda Brahman of sound"
- and the third, **Parabrahman**

"Has everyone understood Akshara Brahman? Is Akshara Brahman making sense or not?"

5. Not Just Utterance, but Contemplation of the Meaning

Here is the subtlest point of the chapter. The verse says: uttering Om, and contemplating Me, the Nirguna Brahman that is its meaning.

"Who will look at the meaning? It says one should understand the meaning."

"This Nirguna Brahman is the original. The syllable-form Brahman is only the word that names it. To get there, first understand its meaning."

The **vachaka** is the word that names something and points to it. The syllable "Om" is the pointer; what it points to is the Nirguna Brahman, the Absolute without attributes. Acharya Ji asks what is to be contemplated, the syllable or the Nirguna

Brahman, and then puts the seeker's real difficulty in front of them:

"But I don't know the Nirguna at all, I don't understand it at all, so there is no benefit in my saying this syllable Om. Is this much making sense? I am showing you this by teaching the Bhagavad Gita."

Uttering Om without understanding its meaning is not enough. It is the one who leaves the body while contemplating that Nirguna Brahman who reaches the supreme goal. And who will do this?

"The one who is devoted to the Akshara Brahman."

6. "Ca": A Small Word, a Big Mistake

Acharya Ji then takes us to the fifth verse of the eighth chapter:

anta-kāle ca mām eva smaran muktvā kalevaram
yaḥ prayāti sa mad-bhāvaṁ yāti nāsty atra
saṁśayaḥ

"And whoever, at the time of the end too, departs
leaving the body while remembering Me alone,
attains My being; of this there is no doubt."

— Bhagavad Gita 8.5

The person who leaves the body remembering Me alone even
at the time of the end attains My very nature; of this there is
no doubt. The whole meaning rests on one small word:

"Is 'ca' written there or not? Read the 'ca' there.

'Antakāle ca': 'ca' means **and**. People always forget that
word 'ca'. People think, 'I only have to say Om at the
time of death.' So if you said Om only at the time of
death, there is no liberation."

Acharya Ji points out how much importance Adi
Shankaracharya gave to this word:

"Shankaracharya Ji has explained so much on this word 'ca'! His analysis, his commentary on this word 'ca': he probably gave a few pages on just that."

"'Antakāle ca mām eva': the whole **life, and at the end moment**. The one who does it, for him liberation has been promised."

In the Hindi translation the same point lies in the word "bhi", **even at the time of the end**:

"'Bhi': it said **even in the last time**. Which means he must have been doing it in the earlier **times** as well, no?"

And then a blunt example:

"If he remembers his girlfriend before and says Om at the last moment, there is no liberation for him."

7. Death Gives No Warning

Even if saying Om at the final moment were enough, one problem would remain:

"But do you know what the problem is? I can't even tell when my end is."

"For birth, you at least get a warning nine months in advance; at the time of death you don't get even nine seconds of warning."

So the conclusion is clear:

"I cannot calculate the last minute, so that I say Om now. That is why I have to do it **treating every moment as the last minute.**"

8. As the Feeling, So the Next Birth

The next verse tells us what decides the thought that comes to mind at the final moment:

**yaṁ yaṁ vāpi smaran bhāvaṁ tyajaty ante
kalevaram**

taṁ tam evaiti kaunteya sadā tad-bhāva-bhāvitaḥ

"Whatever state of being one remembers when leaving the body at the end, that alone one attains, O son of Kunti, having always been absorbed in that state."

— Bhagavad Gita 8.6

O son of Kunti, whatever feeling a person remembers while leaving the body at the end, that alone they attain, because they were always steeped in that feeling.

"Whether your Omkara comes at the last minute will depend entirely on whether you did Om all your life. Otherwise, at your final moment you will have that same desire, you will think that same thing, toward which your destiny is to go."

Acharya Ji explains this with light but pointed examples:

"Hey, 'I want to eat gulab jamun, gulab jamun, I didn't get a samosa': if you did that even after going into the ICU, then in the next birth you might even be born as a beggar outside a sweet shop. Or you might come back as a glutton in some rich house where there is plenty of food."

"That lust, even at the last... then in the next birth you could have a birth like that, or something else. You could be an animal, remember."

And the same law has an auspicious side too:

"If at the end you said 'Guru, Guru', you will be born near the Guru once again."

9. The Final Memory Is the Essence of the Whole Life

"Sadā tad-bhāva-bhāvitah" means the feeling in which one was always steeped. Acharya Ji explains:

"Do you know what you remember at the last minute?
The very thing that was the essence of your whole life."

"You won't remember Om at all at the last minute if
your whole life was 'son, son, son; money, money,
money; tension'."

"Whatever thought is **predominant**, that is the thought
that will come on that day, before dying."

Even if one has done everything (Guru, satsang, sadhana), at
the end the thought that rises will be the one that filled one's
life the most.

10. "Mām Anusmara Yudhya Ca": Remember, and Also Fight

So what is the remedy? The Lord advises Arjuna:

tasmāt sarveṣu kāleṣu mām anusmara yudhya ca
mayy arpita-mano-buddhir mām evaiṣyasy
asaṁśayam

"Therefore, at all times remember Me and fight.
With mind and intellect offered to Me, you will
surely come to Me alone."

— Bhagavad Gita 8.7

Therefore, O Arjuna, remember Me constantly at all times,
and also fight. With mind and intellect offered to Me, you will
without doubt attain Me alone.

Here too there is a "ca": remembrance and battle. You are not
told to give up the work of the world.

"Fight too, that's fine. It means, do whatever work has
to be done."

Acharya Ji brings this "battle" into everyday life:

"If you have to fight with white hair, then even while applying dye, keep saying Om, and understanding what Om is: that inside me, this is temporary. Every battle is temporary. My illness, it is my battle with my body."

Remembering Om while doing every task, with the awareness that all of this is temporary. That is the meaning of "sarveṣu kālēṣu", at all times.

11. Practice Does Not Happen at the Last Moment

The next verse names this practice, *abhyasa-yoga*, the yoga of practice:

**abhyāsa-yoga-yuktena cetasā nānya-gāminā
paramaṁ puruṣaṁ divyaṁ yāti pārthānucintayan**

"With a mind disciplined by the yoga of practice,
not wandering elsewhere, constantly
contemplating, O Partha, one attains the supreme
divine Person."

— Bhagavad Gita 8.8

O Partha, a person joined to the yoga of practice in meditation on the Lord, constantly contemplating with a mind that does not wander elsewhere, attains the supreme, luminous, divine Person, that is, the Lord. Acharya Ji's question is its own answer:

"Can practice happen at the last minute? Does practice happen at the last minute?"

12. Anta Mati So Gati: As the Final Thought, So the Destination

Acharya Ji ties the whole teaching to a well-known saying, and gives it new depth:

"'Anta mati so gati': that is correct. But which mati will there be at the end, that is what I am telling you. The direction you have kept your whole life will become the mati at the end, and the next journey will follow from it."

Mati is the mind's inclination, the direction of thought; **gati** is the onward journey. The inclination at the final moment is simply the result of the direction of one's whole life.

"So **it is not** saying Om at the last minute. First understand Om in your life, and then say it with understanding, in line with Akshara Brahman and Shabda Brahman. Only then does it give its benefit."

13. The Meaning of Om Comes from the Guru

Finally, Acharya Ji tells us where this meaning of Om is to be learned:

"Either someone has **actually** heard that Om and understood it: you will have to take initiation from them, **and** slowly you will also have to understand its meaning from them."

Om is not just a word read in a book. One has to take initiation from a Guru who has truly heard and understood it, and slowly take in its meaning.

Conclusion: Key Teachings

- 1 The method for the final hour:** close the doors of the senses, settle the mind in the heart with selfless love, and gather the prana at the third eye while remembering the Guru.

- 2 **Om is the word; the Nirguna Brahman is what it names.** Merely uttering Om without understanding its meaning bears no fruit. What is to be contemplated is the Nirguna Brahman to which Om points.
- 3 **"Antakāle ca": do not forget the "ca".** Liberation comes to the one who remembers God throughout life **and** at the final moment too.
- 4 **Death gives no warning.** So sadhana must be done treating every moment as the last.
- 5 **The final memory is the essence of the whole life.** The thought that filled one's life is the thought that rises at the end, and it sets the direction of the next birth.
- 6 **"Mām anusmara yudhya ca":** the work of the world is not to be abandoned. Remember Om while doing every task, with the awareness that everything is temporary.
- 7 **Practice does not happen at the last moment.** Abhyasa-yoga is the practice of a whole lifetime.
- 8 **Anta mati so gati:** the direction of one's whole life becomes the final thought.

- 9 **The meaning of Om comes from the Guru:** take initiation from someone who has truly heard and understood Om, and slowly come to understand its meaning.